

Obsidian_Genealogy_Handout_Combined



Teaching Genealogists AI™
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Obsidian for Your Genealogy AI Notes

A Beginner's Guide

You already know how to chat with an AI tool like ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or Perplexity and ask it genealogy questions. The problem: every good answer it gives you, a timeline, a transcription, a research plan, lives inside that chat and is hard to find again next month. Obsidian solves that. This guide gets you from "never opened Obsidian" to touring its interface and saving your first AI answer.

1. What Is Obsidian?

Obsidian is a free note-taking app. Unlike Google Docs or a chat window, it stores every note as a plain text file on your own computer, in a format called Markdown, the same format your AI tool already writes in.

How can it help with my genealogy research?

Every note is a real file in a real folder on your computer, not a record locked inside someone else's database. You can organize by person, family, place, or source, and link them together so you can jump from an ancestor to their sources, timeline, and research log with a click.

How can it help me when using AI?

That Markdown match matters. When your AI tool hands you a formatted answer (headings, bullet points, bold names), Obsidian displays it exactly as intended with a simple copy and paste. No reformatting, no lost structure. The core idea: your AI chatbot is where you *ask* questions. Obsidian is where you *keep* the answers, permanently, searchable, and linked to the rest of your family research.

How much does it cost?

Obsidian is free for personal use, including all genealogy research. Optional paid add-ons exist (cloud sync, publishing a vault as a website), but you do not need either one to use Obsidian for your research notes.

Is it easy to learn?

Yes. You do not need to learn Markdown before using Obsidian; you can begin by typing normally and format as you go. You also do not need to memorize keyboard shortcuts or every button in the interface before it becomes useful. Start with one note, add one link, and continue from there.

2. How to Install

1. Go to <https://obsidian.md>
2. Click **Download**. The site detects whether you are on Mac or Windows.
3. Open the downloaded installer and follow the prompts. There is nothing to configure yet, just Next/Install/Finish.
4. Launch Obsidian.

Create Your First Vault

Obsidian calls a folder of notes a **vault**. Everything for one project lives in one vault.

1. On first launch, choose **Create new vault**.
2. Name it something clear: `Genealogy Notes`.
3. Choose where it lives on your computer (Documents is fine). Obsidian creates the folder for you.
4. Click **Create**.

You now have an empty vault and are looking at Obsidian's main window: a note area in the center, a file list on the left.

Set Up Four Folders

Right-click the file list on the left and choose **New folder** four times, to create:

Folder	What goes here
Ancestors	One note per person: what you know about them

Folder	What goes here
Research Logs	Dated entries: what you searched, what you found or did not find
Sources	Transcriptions and citations for individual records
AI Chats	Full AI answers you want to keep, before you have sorted them

You do not need more folders than this to start. You can always add more later; Obsidian does not lock you into a structure.

3. Obsidian - User Interface

A quick tour of the screen before you start adding your own notes. Open your vault and open (or create) an ancestor note, for example `David Stephenson Beattie`, to follow along.

The Workspace

Obsidian calls the entire window the **workspace**. It has four main areas: a narrow ribbon along the far left, a left sidebar, the main note area in the center, and a right sidebar. There is also a small status bar along the bottom. The layout can be rearranged, but the default is enough to start.

The Ribbon

The narrow strip of icons on the far left is the **ribbon**. Its buttons are shortcuts to frequently used commands; which ones appear can vary depending on which built-in features are enabled. Near the bottom is the gear icon that opens **Settings**. You do not need to memorize these icons: resting the pointer over one shows its name.

The Left Sidebar and File Explorer

The left sidebar is where you normally browse your vault. The **File Explorer** shows the folders and files inside it, real folders and files on your computer, not records locked inside an Obsidian database. Expand `Ancestors` and `Sources`, then select the `David Stephenson Beattie` note to open it in the center. Selecting any filename opens that note.

The Main Note Area

The large center area is where you read and edit notes. The filename appears at the top, and the note's contents appear underneath it. A note can contain ordinary text, headings, lists, links, tables, images, PDFs, and other attachments. Obsidian notes are Markdown files (`.md`), which is simply plain text with a small amount of formatting; you can begin by typing normally.

Try it: select a blank line in `David Stephenson Beattie` and type a short example such as `Research priority: resolve the 1817 vs. 1819 birth-date conflict.` Bold "Research priority" using the normal formatting controls or keyboard shortcut, then undo the change if this is a demonstration copy.

Tabs

Every note opens in a **tab**, much like a page in a web browser. Tabs let you keep several related notes open at once, for example an ancestor note, a source note, and a research log, all together. Closing a tab does not delete the note.

Links Between Notes

Text shown as a link connects one note to another in the vault. `David Stephenson Beattie`'s note can link to his wife `Angeline Telitha Howell`, a place (`Platte County, Missouri`), and a census source; selecting any of those links jumps straight to that note.

To create a link, type two opening square brackets and start typing the name of another note: `[[`. Obsidian suggests matching notes as you type; pick one to insert the link. For example, inside a `Beattie` timeline note, typing `[[David Stephenson Beattie]]` links back to his main note, and inside `Charles Paul Schindhelm`'s main note, typing `[[Charles Paul Schindhelm - 1883 Marriage Transcription]]` links to that source. You do not need to remember a file's folder or full filename; Obsidian finds it for you. This is what separates Obsidian from a folder of Word documents: every note can point to every other related note, so you can jump from a person, to their timeline, to their sources, to the research log that found them, all by clicking.

The Right Sidebar

The right sidebar helps you understand the note you currently have open. Depending on which tab you select, it can show notes that link to this note, links going out from this note, the note's headings, tags or properties, or a local graph of nearby connections. For genealogy, **Backlinks** are especially helpful: they answer "where else have I mentioned this person, place, or source?"

Search

Search looks across the entire vault, not just filenames. Try searching for `Schindhelm` and note every file that contains the term, then clear the search.

The Command Palette

Press **Command-P** (Mac) or **Control-P** (Windows) to open the **Command Palette**, a searchable list of everything Obsidian can do. If you cannot remember where a command lives, open this palette and type what you want, for example "graph," "new note," "backlinks," or

"settings." You do not need to learn a large collection of keyboard shortcuts; remembering this one is enough.

Editing and Reading Views

Obsidian can display a note in an editing view or a reading view. In **Editing view**, you change the note, and with Live Preview enabled, most formatting appears while you type. In **Reading view**, the note is presented for comfortable reading and links remain selectable. Most research sessions stay in Live Preview.

Attachments

Obsidian can keep PDFs and images inside the vault as ordinary files, opened directly or displayed inside a note. The real 1860 census image already on file for Charles Paul Schindhelm (`families/Schindhelm/CharlesPaul_Schindhelm/images/1860-Census-CharlesPaulSchindhelm.jpeg`) is a working example: keeping the record close to its transcription, the people named in it, your analysis, and the questions it raises. The image is the evidence; the note is your working interpretation. Do not confuse the two.

Graph View

Graph View displays the links among your notes and can help you notice clusters involving a person, family, place, or source. The goal is not a beautiful graph; it is useful only when the underlying notes and connections help your research.

Quick Recap

The areas you will use most are: File Explorer to find notes, the center area to read and edit, links to move through the research, Backlinks to see related notes, Search to find information, and Settings for basic configuration. You do not have to learn every button before Obsidian becomes useful.

4. Obsidian and AI

Your AI chatbot is where you *ask*. Obsidian is where you *keep* the answer, permanently, searchable, and linked to the rest of your research.

The Core Workflow

Five steps, every time:

1. **Ask** your AI chatbot a genealogy question, in whatever tool you already use.

2. **Copy** its answer (select all, Ctrl+C or Cmd+C).
3. In Obsidian, click the **New note** icon (top of the file list, looks like a page with a plus sign).
4. **Paste** the answer, then give the note a clear title at the top: ancestor name plus topic, for example `David Stephenson Beattie – Timeline`.
5. **Move** the note into the right folder by dragging it in the file list, and **link** it to the person's main note.

That is the whole loop. No plugins, no settings changes, required to do this.

Worked Examples

A timeline. Ask your AI tool: "Using these facts about David Stephenson Beattie, born 1817 in Pulaski County, Kentucky, married 1843, died 1864 in Platte County, Missouri, build a chronological timeline, and flag it if two of my sources disagree on a date." It returns a bulleted, dated list, and flags the birth-date conflict already noted in Section 3 (1 Feb 1817 vs. 30 Jan 1819). File the resulting note under `Ancestors`.

A record transcription. Photograph a record, for example the 1883 Missouri marriage license for Charles Paul Schindhelm, and ask your AI tool to transcribe it into a table and flag any handwriting it isn't sure about. Paste the result into a note titled `Charles Paul Schindhelm – 1883 Marriage Transcription`, filed under `Sources`, keeping the original image filename in the note so you can always match the transcription back to the record.

Creating a Research Log File

Data: Provide a Link from FamilySearch

Start from the record itself. Open the record on FamilySearch, then use **Share** → **Copy Link** to get a permanent link (FamilySearch record links follow an ARK format, for example `https://www.familysearch.org/ark:/61903/1:1:XXXX-XXX`). Paste that link into your note along with the fields you want the AI to work from, for example the household and ages listed on the Charles Paul Schindhelm 1880 census entry already documented in this vault.

Prompt

Ask your AI tool something like: "Here is a FamilySearch link and the field data from an 1880 census entry for Charles Paul Schindhelm's household. Turn this into a clean research-log entry: what repository and collection this came from, what the record confirms, what is new compared to what I already knew, and what questions remain."

It returns a structured entry, for example:

2026-09-03 Schindhelm 1880 Census

Repository: FamilySearch, 1880 U.S. Census

Link: [FamilySearch ARK link pasted above]

Confirms: Charles P. Schindhelm's household composition and residence in 1880.

New: Ages and birthplaces for household members not previously logged.

Still open: Whether this matches the same household later found in Carroll County, Missouri records.

Paste that into a dated note under `Research Logs`, for example `2026-09-03 Schindhelm 1880 Census`, and link it to `[[Charles Paul Schindhelm]]`. Six months from now, this is how you remember what you already tried and what the record actually said, instead of re-reading the whole census image again.

The rule for all of these examples: AI output is a draft, not evidence. Keep it in Obsidian as your working notes, but any fact that goes into a family history or publication still needs to trace back to the original record.

Golden Rules

1. **AI output is a draft, not evidence.** Verify every fact against the original record before it goes in a family history.
2. **One note, one idea.** A person, a record, or a research session, not all three crammed into one note.
3. **Link instead of duplicate.** If a fact belongs in two places, link to the note that has it rather than copying the text twice.
4. **Protect the living.** Do not paste identifying details about living relatives into any AI tool, and be thoughtful about what you store even in Obsidian.
5. **File as you go.** A note left in `AI Chats` and never filed is a note you will not find again. Move it the same day.

Where to Go Next

- <https://obsidian.md/help/>: Obsidian's own official help documentation, including the Workspace overview, Sidebars, Settings, Core plugins, and Create a vault pages. Also reachable from inside the app through **Settings -> General -> Help -> Open**.
- <https://obsidian.rocks/getting-started-with-obsidian-a-beginners-guide/>: an independent beginner's walkthrough.
- This [2026 beginner tutorial](#) includes a useful interface segment beginning around 7:39, followed by tabs, folders, notes, settings, Markdown, links, and Graph View. It is third-party

material and covers several advanced subjects you can skip.

Everything genealogy-specific in this guide is what you build yourself, one AI answer at a time.

*Want more? The full **Teaching Genealogists AI** curriculum covers prompt crafting, AI safety, hallucination, bias, and GPS-compliant research workflows. Contact Sylvia Vargas.*

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